



PITTSBURGH

PAINTING & PROPERTY SOLUTIONS

FREE HOMEOWNER'S GUIDE

The Pittsburgh Homeowner's Exterior Paint Checklist

12 things Western PA weather does to a paint job — and the specific questions that separate a bid that lasts ten years from one that fails in three.

Questions? Call Brian direct

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Read this before you accept any bid

Three contractors will walk your house and hand you three numbers. The numbers will not be close to each other, and the difference almost never comes down to greed. It comes down to **what got left out of the cheap one**.

This checklist gives you the twelve things that actually determine whether your paint lasts, and the exact question to ask about each. Take it with you to every walk-through — including ours.

What this climate does

Western Pennsylvania puts a specific set of stresses on an exterior finish. Understanding them is most of what you need to judge a bid.

THE STRESS	WHAT IT DOES TO YOUR HOUSE
Freeze–thaw cycling	Water gets into an open joint, freezes, expands roughly 9%, and levers the coating off the substrate. Pittsburgh crosses freezing in both directions dozens of times a winter. This is the single biggest killer of exterior paint here.
Wet springs	Substrate that never fully dries. Coating applied over damp wood blisters as the moisture tries to escape.
Mature tree canopy	North elevations stay damp and shaded and grow mildew fast. Painting over mildew just feeds it under the film.
Road salt & grit	Chews at the lower three feet of the house and anything near a driveway or steps.
A century of brick	Old soft brick and lime mortar need to breathe. Seal them with the wrong coating and they spall — the face of the brick pops off. That damage is permanent.
Hillside exposure	Half the city sits on a slope, so one elevation catches far more weather and UV than the others and ages twice as fast.

The short version

If you only remember one thing: **ninety percent of exterior paint failure is prep failure, not paint failure**. The product on the can matters far less than what happened to the surface in the three days before it went on. Every question in this checklist is really a question about prep.

1

Is the house getting washed — and then allowed to dry?

Dirt, chalk, pollen and mildew all break adhesion. Washing is standard; the part crews skip is the **drying**. Substrate needs a genuine dry-out, not a few hours.

ASK

How many days between the wash and the first coat?

2

How much scraping and sanding is included?

Loose material has to come off, and the hard edge left behind has to be feathered smooth or it telegraphs straight through the new finish.

ASK

Is scraping capped at a number of hours, or is it "until it's sound"?

3

Who is fixing the rot — and is it in this price?

Soft sills, fascia and trim will not hold paint. Painting over rot buys one season and costs you the whole job. It should appear as a visible line item, not a surprise later.

ASK

Show me the rot you found, and where the repair sits on this quote.

4

Is every bare surface getting primed?

Bare wood, bare metal and every repair need the right primer — stain-blocking, bonding or rust-inhibitive depending on what it's going over. "The paint is self-priming" is not an answer for bare substrate.

ASK

Which primer, on which surfaces?

5

What exactly is getting caulked?

This is the freeze-thaw defence and the most commonly skipped step in the trade. Trim-to- siding joints, window and door surrounds, and every gap water can find.

ASK

Which joints, and what grade of caulk?

6

One coat or two?

The most common hidden difference between two bids. One coat looks identical on handover day and fails in roughly half the time. Get the number in writing.

ASK

Is two coats written on the quote, or just discussed?

7

Is the paint being spread at the rated thickness?

Every product has a manufacturer's spread rate. Stretching a bucket further is invisible on day one and is exactly how a "two coat" job performs like one.

ASK

How many gallons are budgeted for this house?

8

If it's brick — is the coating breathable?

Old Pittsburgh brick must release moisture. A non-breathable film traps water, and the freeze–thaw cycle then pops the face off the brick. That is not repairable by repainting. Brick also needs repointing and full drying **first**.

ASK

Which masonry system, and is my brick actually a candidate?

9

How is the north side being treated?

Shaded, damp elevations need mildewcide treatment during the wash, not a coat of paint over live growth.

ASK

What are you doing differently on the shaded elevations?

10

What's the plan when it rains?

A crew chasing a deadline through a wet forecast will coat damp substrate and it will blister. You want to hear that they stop and come back.

ASK

What's your minimum surface temperature and dry-time rule?

11

Same crew every day, or whoever's free?

Rotating subcontractors is where agreed details get lost. It is a quality question, not a nosy one.

ASK

Who specifically is on my property, and are they employees or subs?

12

Is there a written warranty — and proof of insurance?

A workmanship warranty should be on paper with a stated term. Ask every bidder for their certificate of insurance. Anyone who hesitates has told you something important.

ASK

Can I see the certificate and the warranty wording before I sign?

When to paint in Western PA

WINDOW	VERDICT
Late Apr – May	Workable, but wet. Expect weather delays.
June – July	Fine, though high humidity slows cure and afternoon storms cost days.
Aug – Oct	The best window. Lower humidity, more workable days, proper cure before the first freeze.
Nov – Mar	Exteriors stop below roughly 50°F surface temp. The right time for interiors, cabinets and basements — and the easiest time to get on a schedule.

What things generally cost here

Ranges, not quotes — but if a bid sits far below the bottom of one of these, something has been left out, and it is worth finding out what.

WORK	TYPICAL PITTSBURGH RANGE
Full exterior repaint, two-story	\$4,500 – \$12,000
Interior, per room (walls, ceiling, trim)	\$450 – \$900
Kitchen cabinet refinishing	\$3,000 – \$6,500
Basement walls sealed, coated + floor	Quoted per property

Five red flags on a bid

- 1. A single lump-sum number.** If it isn't itemized you cannot tell what's missing, which is usually the point.

2. No mention of primer or caulk. The two steps that decide the lifespan.

3. A large deposit up front. A staged schedule tied to milestones is normal; most of the money before work starts is not.
- 4. Pressure to sign today.** A real quote is still valid next week. Discounts that expire when the salesperson leaves your kitchen are a sales tactic.

5. Hesitation about insurance. If someone gets hurt on your property and the contractor isn't covered, that can land on your homeowner's policy.

Our written prep spec

We publish this because it is the part of the job you cannot see once the paint is on. It goes on every estimate we write, so you can hold us to it — and so you have something concrete to compare the other two bids against.

#	STEP
1	Pressure wash the entire envelope. Treat mildew. Let it dry fully.
2	Scrape and sand every failing edge, feathered so it doesn't telegraph.
3	Repair or replace rotted trim, sills and fascia.
4	Spot-prime every bare surface with the correct primer for that substrate.
5	Caulk every open joint — trim-to-siding, window and door surrounds.
6	Mask and protect windows, roofing, hardware, walks and landscaping.
7	Two full coats of Sherwin-Williams at the rated spread rate.
8	Walk the house together with a punch list before the balance is due.

Free with every estimate

See your house in the new color first

Every estimate includes a free colour consultation and a digital rendering of your actual home in the colours you're considering — before you commit a dollar. It settles the argument in about thirty seconds.

Written, itemised quote within 24 hours of the walk-through. No pressure, no expiring price, no ninety-minute sales pitch at your kitchen table.

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